To: Tech Nation UK

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RECOMMENDATION FOR EXCEPTIONAL TALENT

My name is Chukwuwezam Obanor. I founded PrepClassNG, a Lagos-based education technology company, and I have spent the better part of the last decade building and observing the Nigerian tech ecosystem from the inside. I am writing about Raphael Obodugo because I knew him before the accolades, and what I saw then is what makes me confident now.

Raphael joined PrepClass as a fullstack software engineer in October 2018. He was young, but he was not junior in the way that word usually implies, someone who needs to be told what to do and closely watched to make sure they do it. He came in with opinions about architecture, a natural instinct for what would break under load, and an impatience with solutions that were merely adequate. At a startup, that combination is either a gift or a friction point depending on how it is channelled. In Raphael's case, it was entirely a gift. He left in October 2019 to pursue bigger stages, and I was not surprised.

What happened next I watched from the outside, the way you watch someone you backed early. He moved through increasingly demanding international roles, open finance infrastructure in Paris, engineering leadership in Berlin, a founding engineer seat at a Y Combinator-backed payments company in Singapore. Each move was upward and outward, but he never seemed to lose the thread back to the problem he actually cared about: what does financial infrastructure look like when it is built for how West Africans actually live?

MySub was the answer to that question. A pooled payment platform, for rent, subscriptions, school fees, the informal group-spending that the

region had been running over WhatsApp for years. He built it without outside capital, grew it to 360,000 users, and eventually took it through a strategic acquisition. I have seen many Nigerian founders chase that trajectory. Very few complete it, and almost none without venture funding. That he did it while simultaneously holding senior engineering roles abroad tells you something important about the kind of operator he is.

His intention is to develop his AI company, AVAE, from the United Kingdom. I can speak to why that matters for both sides: Raphael is not the kind of person who settles into an ecosystem passively. When he was at PrepClass, he was already thinking about what the engineering culture around him could become. That instinct has not changed. The UK will gain a technically serious founder with a demonstrated track record across three continents, and a genuine orientation toward building things that work rather than things that raise.

I have watched Raphael grow from a sharp young engineer on my team into one of the most complete technical founders I know on this continent. I recommend him without reservation for the UK Global Talent Visa. UK will be gaining someone who builds things that last.

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